

Activity Report 2023-24

ABWCI

Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry

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1. About ABWCI

The Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry (ABWCI) is a virtual chamber for women in business; empowering them through a supportive ecosystem, fostering equity, and inclusive prosperity for a thriving society. ABWCI is a membership-based network, connecting women across diverse sectors.

Registered as a Not For Profit under Section 8 of the Indian Companies Act, 2013, ABWCI was officially launched in 2021; with the aim to empower, engage, and educate women in business, while advocating for policies that foster a collaborative ecosystem globally.

Vision

- Empowering women in business through a supportive ecosystem, fostering equity, and inclusive prosperity for a thriving society.
- We want women to be wealth creators and not job seekers.

Objectives

- To empower, engage and educate women in business, while advocating for policies that foster a collaborative ecosystem globally.

ABWCI celebrates and enables women's business acumen & ambition by connecting members to investors, incubators, accelerators, traditional donors, thought leaders, academia, professional development resources, and relevant opportunities.

The primary focus areas are:

- Access to Market
- Access to Finance
- Access to Technology
- Access to Entrepreneurial Ecosystems

Recognitions

- Member of UNFPA's Equity 2030 Alliance
- Knowledge partner of the UNGCNI
- Knowledge partner of the G20/W20 in 2023
- Listed on the Social Stock Exchange (NSE, India)

ABWCI's value proposition lies in the multifaceted approach to empower women entrepreneurs, fostering connections, providing opportunities, and advocating for supportive ecosystems that contribute to economic growth and societal well-being. The Chamber is committed to creating a robust community of women entrepreneurs; providing them with opportunities to access investment capital, trade networks & entrepreneurial education; and advocating for policies resulting in women - centric entrepreneurial ecosystems worldwide.

2. Activities undertaken in the FY 2023-24

ABWCI Strategic Focus for 2023-24

This year, ABWCI had prioritized scaling its impact by forging strategic partnerships with key stakeholders in the entrepreneurship ecosystem. These collaborations were forged to significantly expand our outreach, enabling us to engage a broader network of women entrepreneurs and providing them with access to networks that enhance their growth and sustainability. By collaborating with both public and private sector entities, our aim was to build and strengthen a robust ecosystem that empowers women entrepreneurs.

A key focus of our initiatives this year has been aligning with the Government of India's agenda for women-led development under India's W20/G20 presidency. Many of our activities and partnerships have centred around this alignment, ensuring that our efforts contribute to the larger national and global goals of promoting gender equality and women's leadership in development.

Additionally, we have been actively collaborating with other players in the entrepreneurship ecosystem to design and implement impactful programs for women entrepreneurs. These joint efforts have allowed us to leverage collective expertise and resources to deliver high-quality, scalable programs that address the unique challenges faced by women in business and entrepreneurship.

Listed on Social Stock Exchange

on



ABWCI listed on the Social Stock Exchange (National Stock Exchange, India) – reflecting our commitment to social impact and responsible business practices. The SSE segment on NSE provides Social Enterprises (Non-profit organizations) engaged in eligible activities a unique opportunity to register itself and raise funds on a recognized exchange platform.

Launch of WomenInVyapaar

As a proud W20 knowledge partner and a global chamber of commerce, ABWCI brings to you *WomenInVyapaar*, a global initiative for supporting and creating women - centric entrepreneurial ecosystems.

WOMEN
in
VYAPAAR

The primary objective of *WomenInVyapaar* is as follows:

- Create a robust community of women entrepreneurs
- Provide access to investment capital & trade networks
- Enable entrepreneurial education
- Policy advocacy for women - centric global entrepreneurial ecosystems worldwide



Buyer-seller meet

The Buyer - Seller Meet of the last quarter of 2023 provided a dynamic platform for women entrepreneurs to network and collaborate.

Through engaging conversations and demonstrations, the entrepreneurs showcased their products and services which led to the development of business opportunities & synergies. ABWCI organizes a wide range of events, conferences, and meet-ups to further the agenda of women's social & economic empowerment.



Representation of ABWCI Leaders at various forums

- Kavita Rajesh, State President, Telangana & Andhra Pradesh attended the first conference of legislators in India aimed at extending their role as elected representatives. ABWCI presented a concept on setting up WEECs (Women Empowerment and Entrepreneurship Centers) to scale up women led development at the grassroots.
- Kavita Rajesh was a speaker at the National Conference on Women Entrepreneurship in Hyderabad, India.

3. Networking & Outreach

✚ Recognized as Knowledge Partner for G20/W20



➤ W20 meeting at Jaipur

Team ABWCI participated in the W20 meeting held in Jaipur, committing towards the evolution of women to women led development. The two-day dialogue was themed, “Women-Led Development: Leveraging Women’s Untapped Potential to Accelerate an Inclusive and Sustainable Future”.



➤ W20 Summit at Mahabalipuram

Team ABWCI participated in the W20 Summit held in Mahabalipuram, Tamil Nadu, India. The summit revolved around the themes of trade, care economy and women empowerment on a policy level. This Summit came up with an extensive Communique to advance Women-Led Development.



➤ **Partnership with FKCCI Bengaluru and Ubuntu for G20 event**

ABWCI joined the consortium to support the event under the aegis of G20/W20. Our Founder Secretary General, Mr. Parul Soni moderated the panel on “Policy recommendation for creating an enabling ecosystem for women entrepreneurs.



➤ **Jan Bhagidari Events under G20/W20 partnerships**

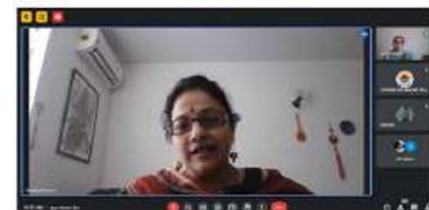
SheLeads: A Vision for Future

ABWCI and Women's Studies Research Centre at Kurukshetra University, in collaboration with Stree Shakti, organized a one-day online training programme. This programme was a W20 JanBhagidari event that aimed at strengthening women’s leadership in India and witnessed active participation from ABWCI’s Leadership.



➤ **Empowering Grassroots Women Entrepreneurs**

ABWCI organized this W20 JanBhagidari event in partnership with Divinpro and WICCI. The event was aimed towards unlocking economic growth & sustainability for all. The panelists also talked about the pivotal role of grassroot women entrepreneurs in achieving sustainable economic growth and gender equality which is one of the key priorities of G20/W20.



➤ **Breaking the Glass Ceiling**

ABWCI organised a captivating panel discussion titled, "Breaking the Glass Ceiling" under the aegis of the G20/W20 Secretariat and *WomenInVyapaar*. The panel discussion was a W20 Jan Bhagidari event powered by Women Inspiring Network (WIN) and supported by Thinkthrough Consulting (TTC).

Women changemakers and digital content curators shared their personal experiences to inspire the audience to push their limits in search of excellence. The discussions were passionate, insightful and provided guidance for the next generation.



➤ Launch of the Shakti Cart

The Shakti Cart is a livelihood cart specially designed for the economic inclusion of women street vendors to increase their visibility and mobility in public spaces. The cart was inaugurated at all India premier of the mainstream Bollywood movie, Ghoomer. ABWCI is proud to be associated with 'Shakti Cart', a Make in India initiative by PVR NEST, conceptualized and designed by Desmania Designed for Good. This supports the vision to enable women's business acumen and ambitions with relevant opportunities. At this event, ABWCI and PVR Nest also presented a CSR film on “Building Safe Cities for Women and Children”.



✚ Knowledge Partners with other agencies

- ABWCI proudly supported The Global FoodBanking Network (GFN) and Thinkthrough Consulting (TTC) in organizing the Global Food Security Summit 2023 (GFSS 2023) under the aegis of India's G20 presidency. The aim of GFSS 2023 was to raise awareness about Food Banking, and its significant role in promoting food security and reducing food loss and food waste globally.
- The summit witnessed a dynamic all-women panel discussion that comprised of visionaries from different domains and organisations such as Government of Karnataka, UN Women, The Global FoodBanking Network, Heifer



International, ABWCI, and Nectar Fresh, came together to explore the critical role women play in advancing food and nutrition security.

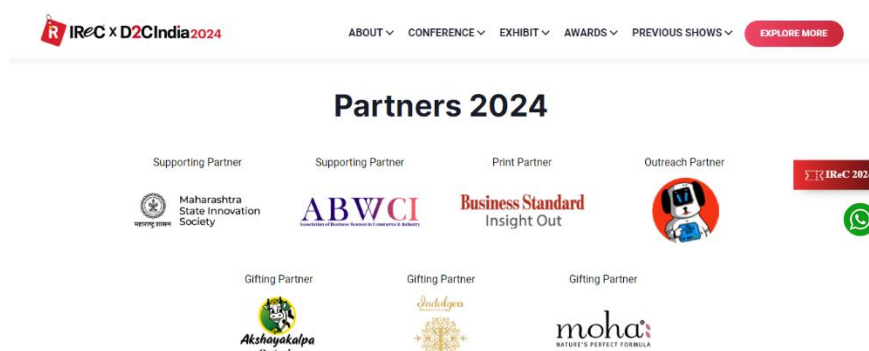
➤ NHRDN for SAMAAVESHAN 2023

ABWCI was a proud knowledge partner at Samaaveshan, NHRDN's DEIB Summit. The theme of the summit was to enable and encourage how DEIB can help individuals in everyday life.



➤ Supporting partner at the IReC Asia × D2C India Conference

ABWCI recognized as the Supporting Partner at the IReC Asia × D2C India Conference, Karnataka, India.



➤ Gender Equality Summit with UNGCNI

UN Global Compact Network India (UNGCNI), functions as the Indian Local Network of the Global Compact, New York. ABWCI was a proud Knowledge Partner for the 7th edition of the Gender Equality Summit in New Delhi. Our founder, Mr. Parul Soni launched the Compendium on Forward Faster- Gender Equality along with other dignitaries on the dias during the inaugural session and moderated the panel titled, "Breaking Barriers: Technology, Innovation, & Inclusion For A Gender Equal Future."



➤ Virtual Conference with GCBL

The virtual conference, "Exclusively About Inclusivity: Speaking On Solutions" hosted by The Association of Business Women in Commerce & Industry (ABWCI) and the Global Chamber of Business Leaders (GCBL) provided exclusive insights about women led development along with the impact it brings to the ecosystem. This conference was designed to foster thought leadership on wide-ranging unique topics.



🌐 Networking and Outreach Partner

➤ Global Economic Summit

ABWCI was recognised as the Networking Partner for the 14th edition of the Global Economic Summit organised by the Federation of Indian Women Entrepreneurs (FIWE). Our Founder, Mr. Parul Soni moderated the Panel on 'Entrepreneurship in the Global Context' at the Summit. The theme of the summit was 'Empowering Women Entrepreneurs to Global Opportunities'.



➤ Networking Partner at WomenPreneurs Awards 2024

ABWCI was recognised as the "Networking Partner" at the WomenPreneur Awards 2024 by HerZindagi.com. Member, Akriti Gupta, Founder of Canfem was conferred with the Rising Star Award for her contribution to the society.



➤ Rashtriya Naari Samman Awards 2024

BrandsGlobal Media organised the Rashtriya Naari Samman Awards 2024 with the aim to celebrate and honour the remarkable achievements of women who have made significant contributions to society. Dedicated to enabling and celebrating women in business, ABWCI supported the event as the Outreach Partner.



➤ Organizing Global Mentoring Walk

The 17th year of the Global Mentoring Walks with the IWD2024 theme of InspireInclusion. ABWCI and Women Inspiring Network joined forces for the Global Mentoring Walk to celebrate Women's History Month.



➤ **Consultation on Gender Mainstreaming organized by UNDP**

ABWCI was recognised as the knowledge partner by UNDP. Many leaders from ABWCI were invited to share their insights at the 'International Consultation on Gender Mainstreaming in Development Initiatives' organised by the Ministry of Rural Development, the Government of Karnataka & UNDP.



4. Way Forward

ABWCI will place a strong emphasis on skill development for women across both urban and rural settings. Key initiatives will include:

- Developing tailored training programs that address the specific needs of women in various regions, with a focus on enhancing their ability to produce high-quality products.
- Facilitate access to resources for scaling their businesses.
- Collaborating with state governments to organize programmes on skill development and entrepreneurship.

ABWCI will also convene regular meetings—both virtual and in-person—to discuss the challenges, opportunities, and growth strategies for women-led businesses. These meetings will:

- Feature guest speakers who are successful women entrepreneurs, offering inspiration and mentorship to emerging businesswomen.
- Identify and recognize successful women entrepreneurs, showcasing them as role models for others.

In its broader vision, ABWCI will work on developing an ecosystem that nurtures and supports women entrepreneurs from all sections and geographies. This ecosystem will:

- Provide ongoing mentoring and coaching support to women at various stages of their entrepreneurial journeys.
- Connect women entrepreneurs with investors, mentors, and other stakeholders who can contribute to their business growth.
- Advocate for policy changes and initiatives that promote gender equality and bolster support for women in business.

Through these strategic initiatives, ABWCI is steadfast in its commitment to empowering women entrepreneurs, creating opportunities, and fostering a more inclusive and equitable business environment.

Join us in our digital journey

